



Russian Amber Room

△ **Prussian coat of arms** on the south wall

The fate of the Amber Room is one of the great mysteries of modern times. This spectacular chamber was originally commissioned by King Friedrich I of Prussia in 1701. It consisted of a series of richly carved amber panels adorned with semi-precious stones and Florentine mosaics, depicting the five senses. A German sculptor, Andreas Schlüter, and a Danish amber specialist, Gottfried Wolfram, collaborated on the work. In 1716, the panels were presented to the Russian Tsar, Peter the Great, after he admired them during a state visit. He installed them in St Petersburg where they remained until 1755, when the Tsarina Elizabeth had the room enlarged and redesigned so that it would fit into her palace.

The Amber Room remained a prized possession of the Russian state until World War II, when looting German forces dismantled it. The stolen panels were

packed into 27 crates and carried off to Königsberg Castle on the Baltic coast. The trail ends there. The panels may have been destroyed by Allied bombing, or by a fire in the castle – in either case, they had disappeared by the end of the war. A replica of the room was completed in 2003, in St Petersburg, Russia.



Crown-shaped detail carved in amber

Treasure hunters have never given up the search for the original panels, and fanciful theories abound. Some believe the Nazis buried the loot in an underground bunker; others claim the remains of Hitler were interred with the panels. Periodically, there

have been claims of its rediscovery. In 2015, Polish treasure hunters located an armoured train believed to be packed with Nazi booty, buried in tunnels near Książ Castle in Poland. The same year, a German search team explored old copper mines at Deutschneudorf, near the Czech border. Neither find came to anything, and the hunt goes on.



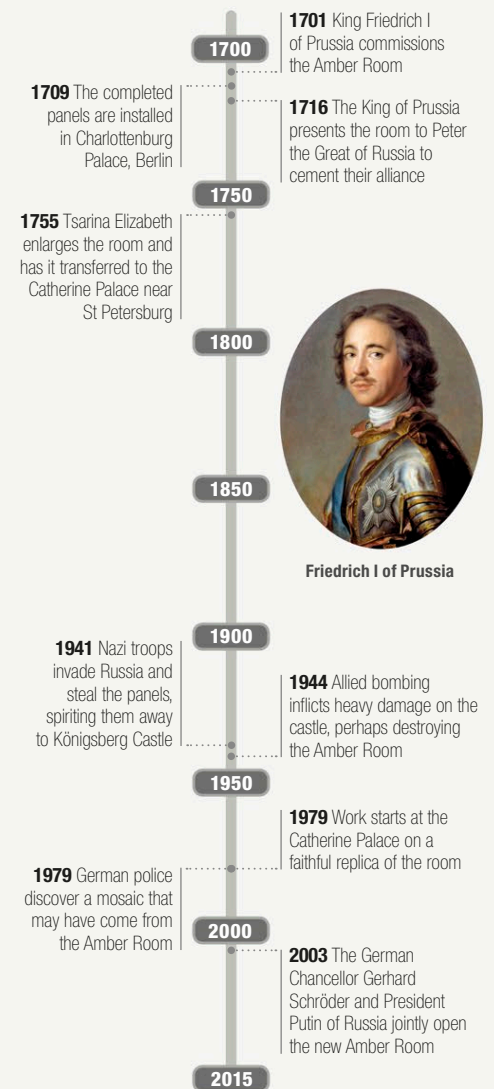
Rococo clock with a highly decorative base mounted on an amber-inlaid table, in the rebuilt Amber Room

The Amber Room has enormous emotional significance for both Germany and Russia

Friedrich **Spath**, chairman of Ruhrgas, corporate donors to the reconstruction project

Key dates

1701–2003



Friedrich I of Prussia